Assignment 08: Goals, Plans, Resumes

CS 140 with Dr. Sam Schwartz

Upload to Canvas when done.

1 Purpose

The purpose of this assignment is to identify goals, make a plan, and create tools to execute this plan.

To paraphrase former US President Eisenhower, "In preparing for battle, I have always found that plans are useless – they never survive contact with the enemy – but planning itself is indispensable."

To paraphrase Benjamin Franklin, "Failing to plan is planning to fail."

2 Tasks

In this assignment you will complete the following three tasks.

Task 1 – Goals

The purpose underlying this task:

To know what to do in life, we need to have a few "guiding lights." These lights need not be permanent – on a personal note, many of my goals changed quite a bit in my early 20s. But it is helpful to have *something* written down, hence we are going to take some time to document a goal hierarchy for ourselves.

Task 1 Required Deliverables

Create a goal hierarchy, like you sketched in class. Think to yourself, "When I die, some 50+ years from now, what do I want to have achieved?"

Type it up (use PowerPoint, paint, Google Docs; use whatever you'd like, just make it look professional), save it as a PDF as `Goals.pdf`, and submit it to Canvas.

Additionally, print out a copy and bring it to class on Friday.

While not required, I find that phrasing each goal in my hierarchy as a SMART goal – specific, measurable, achievable, realistic, time-bound – is a helpful framework. It means that goals at the bottom of my hierarchy are often extremely specific, super measurable, easily achievable, very realistic, and due soon. Goals at the top, while still following this SMART framework, are more ambiguous, perhaps difficult to measure, and challenging to achieve. Nevertheless, I like to have my top-level goals still be realistic and doable before I'm dead.

Task 2 – Plans

The purpose underlying this task:

One of the goals in your hierarchy probably needs to revolve around obtaining "adult-level" income shortly after graduation. There are many ways to do so – marry someone rich, have a diamond-filled meteor fall in your backyard, or get a job; these are just a few examples. Alternatively, you may wish to pursue additional education after graduation.

In any case, it's helpful to make a plan on how you will achieve some of your immediately-after-graduation goals, and provide alternative routes to obtaining them.

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Task 2 Required Deliverables

Create at least three plans – labeled Plan A, Plan B, Plan C – that are focused on how you plan to land that first job, get into grad school, win that first client/customer if self employed, woo that rich significant other, buy land in meteorite-prone areas, or whatever you'd want to do upon graduation that helps advance your goal hierarchy. Identify how computing skills you're learning at UWEC can enable or accelerate at least one element in at least one of your plans.

Type up these 3 (or more) plans, save it as a PDF as `Plans.pdf`, and submit it to Canvas.

Additionally, print out a copy and bring it to class on Friday.

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The purpose for three plans is because the world (and you) change. If plan A doesn't pan out, it's helpful to have pre-identified alternative approaches.

Task 3 – Resume

The purpose underlying this task:

Plans require tools, tactics, and resources to achieve goals. One of the common tools used to achieve the goal of obtaining a job is a resume. (Other tools/tactics/resources commonly involved in permanent job obtainment in computing fields include networking, "informational interviews," internships, and portfolio projects.) It's helpful to get feedback on these tools.

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Task 3 Required Deliverables

Create a resume, CV, or other briefing about yourself – tailored for whatever entity you're hoping to get money from in your "Plan A" of task 2. (For most jobs, that would be a resume; for grad school, that would be a CV; for self-employment, that would be whatever document you'd show potential customers/clients to get them to hire you.

This resume can be either your resume as it reflects reality right now, or an aspirational resume – such as the resume you'd like to have exist at the time of your graduation from UWEC.

Type up this resume, save it as a PDF as `Resume.pdf` or `CV.pdf`, and submit it to Canvas.

Additionally, print out a copy and bring it to class on Friday.

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3 Grading Criteria

This assignment is a bit subjective in it's grading criteria, because the tasks are more creative. In general I am looking for these elements:

Validity

Student submitted a

... Goals.pdf file
... Plans.pdf file
... which contained some indication how the computing skills they're learning at UWEC can be put to use. ...
Resume.pdf or CV.pdf file

Readability

... which used professional English and typesetting throughout all documents.

Fluency

... and the deliverables were executed in such a way that an experienced practitioner would not find the deliverable "weird-in-a-bad-way" or unduly jarring.

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Note that I am not going to be evaluating you on the merits of your goals themselves.

Do you have a goal to become a porn star or stripper in Vegas? A rabbi, imam, minister or priest? Or (one of my personal favorites) a computing professional? Tell me more. America is big and full of people with all sorts of goals, and different personal values which drive them to achieve these goals.

The important thing for this assignment is not my personal opinion on your plans or goals. Rather, the important thing is that (1) you're able to articulate and organize your goals – whatever they may be; (2) you have drafted a few plans to achieve them (especially around your post-graduation goals); and (3) that you have created a key tool (e.g., resume) for your post-graduation plan(s).